



Questions for Open Evenings and Open Days

A week of registrations before an open evening or a university open day, ending in a mini open evening in the classroom. Every student goes home with a list of questions they built themselves.

Before you start. Not every student will be going to an open evening or an open day, and for some what comes next is a difficult subject at home. The activity is about asking, not about where anybody is going, and nobody is asked which evenings they are attending.

Print these

Pages	What it is
Pages 2 and 3	Year 10 and 11 question sheet, one per student, double-sided
Pages 4 and 5	Year 10 and 11 answer cards (about five copies) and stall cards (one copy), cut out
Pages 6 and 7	Sixth form question sheet, one per student, double-sided
Pages 8 and 9	Sixth form answer cards (about five copies) and stall cards (one copy), cut out

The week

Day	What happens	Slide
Monday	Hand out the sheet. Students rank five questions from 1 (must ask) to 5, add one of their own and compare with a partner.	2
Tuesday	Five more, ranked the same way. Each student then copies their top five onto the back.	3
Wednesday	Pairs with a few answer cards. One reads the vague answer, the other follows it up until it is something you could write down. Swap each card.	4
Thursday	Two students for each of the four stalls read their card. Everyone else stars three questions.	5
Friday	Desks become stalls and the visitors go round. See the two ways to run it below.	6
After	The Monday after the real one: which question got the most useful answer?	7

Friday, two ways

Option	How it runs
Quick, 10 to 15 minutes.	One round, with each visitor at one stall. Swap the staff and run a second round the next morning.
Longer, a tutor time or a lesson.	Two or three rounds, swapping the staff halfway, then five minutes on which stall was vaguest.

Worth knowing

- The questions students add themselves are usually the best ones. Leave time for them.
- The places on the stall cards are made up and the gaps are deliberate. "I'd have to find out" is a fair answer.

New resources go up on thepastoralguide.com as they are made. Leave your email there and you will hear when they do.





Build your questions

Each morning, rank the questions from 1 (must ask) to 5 (could skip) in the boxes, and add one of your own. On Tuesday, copy your top five from the whole week onto the back.

NAME

FORM

RANK

MONDAY The course, the day and the people.☐

How is it assessed: exams, coursework, or both?

☐

What did last year's students go on to do?

☐

How many hours a week am I in lessons, and what happens in the gaps?

☐

Who would I go to if I was struggling?

☐

Do students who did not come from this school settle in?

☐

One of my own: _____

TUESDAY Money, getting there, and if it goes wrong.☐

Is there any cost for trips, books or equipment?

☐

Is there a bursary or any help with costs, and how do I apply?

☐

How do most students get here in the morning?

☐

Can I change courses, and until when?

☐

What support is there if my grades are not what I hoped?

☐

One of my own: _____

WEDNESDAY Ask it for real

My best follow-up question, for when an answer is vague:

THURSDAY Set up the open evening☐

I'm a visitor

☐

I'm staff at _____





My questions for the open evening

Your top five from the week, in your own order. Star the three you'll ask on Friday. Take this with you, and when a question is answered, tick it and write down what you found out.

WHERE I'M GOING

WHEN

1



WHAT I FOUND OUT

☐

2



WHAT I FOUND OUT

☐

3



WHAT I FOUND OUT

☐

4



WHAT I FOUND OUT

☐

5



WHAT I FOUND OUT

☐

If an answer is vague, ask:

Who, exactly?

How much?

By when?

Can you give me an example?

SOMETHING I NOTICED THAT NOBODY TOLD ME





Vague answers

Cut out. About five copies is enough for a form. In pairs, one person reads the top of a card out loud and the other follows it up until the answer means something. Show the bottom of the card once they've tried.

THEY SAY

“There’s loads of support here.”

TRY ASKING

“Who exactly would I go to, and how?”

THEY SAY

“Most of our students do really well.”

TRY ASKING

“What did last year’s students go on to do?”

THEY SAY

“It’s a mix of exams and coursework.”

TRY ASKING

“How much of the final grade is exams?”

THEY SAY

“Students settle in really quickly.”

TRY ASKING

“What happens in the first week to help new students?”

THEY SAY

“There’s help with costs if you need it.”

TRY ASKING

“How much, and how do I apply?”

THEY SAY

“You can usually change if it’s not working.”

TRY ASKING

“Until when, and who decides?”

THEY SAY

“The timetable’s quite flexible.”

TRY ASKING

“How many hours a week am I actually in lessons?”

THEY SAY

“Getting here is pretty easy.”

TRY ASKING

“Which buses, and what do they cost?”





Stall cards

Cut out, one copy. Two students run each stall and answer only from their card. The places are made up, and the gaps on the cards are deliberate.

Fernbrook School

A made-up school sixth form

COURSES	24 A level subjects. Most students take three.
ASSESSED	Mostly exams at the end of Year 13. Some subjects have coursework worth a fifth of the grade.
THE DAY	8.40 to 3.10, with about 18 hours of lessons a week. Free periods are in the silent study room.
CLASS SIZES	Usually 12 to 18.
SUPPORT	Your tutor first, then the head of sixth form. A counsellor is in two days a week.
LAST YEAR	About 7 in 10 went to university and 1 in 7 to an apprenticeship.
COSTS	Trips are extra. There is a bursary for students who qualify: ask the office for the form.
CHANGING	You can change a subject in the first three weeks.

Answer from this card. If it isn't here, say "I'd have to find out."
Give one vague answer each round on purpose, and see if they follow it up.

Kestrel Vale College

A made-up further education college

COURSES	A levels, T levels and BTECs in 30 subjects.
ASSESSED	BTECs are mostly coursework with some exams. T levels include a 45-day work placement.
THE DAY	Lessons three and a half days a week, 9.00 to 4.30. No lessons on Wednesday afternoons.
CLASS SIZES	16 to 22.
SUPPORT	A personal tutor, a weekly drop-in, and a student services desk open all day.
SETTLING IN	Most students come from other schools. The first week is all induction.
COSTS	Equipment for some courses is about £50. The bursary covers it if you qualify.
GETTING HERE	A free bus pass if you live more than three miles away.

Answer from this card. If it isn't here, say "I'd have to find out."
Give one vague answer each round on purpose, and see if they follow it up.

Hillmarsh Sixth Form College

A made-up sixth form college

COURSES	40 A level subjects and a few BTECs.
ASSESSED	Mostly exams at the end of Year 13. BTECs are about half coursework.
THE DAY	9.00 to 4.00, but you only come in for your lessons.
FREE PERIODS	The library, the café, or home if you have no more lessons that day.
CLASS SIZES	About 20.
SUPPORT	A personal tutor you meet once a week.
SETTLING IN	1,800 students from 30 schools. Nobody knows anybody at first.
GETTING HERE	Two bus routes stop outside the gate.

Answer from this card. If it isn't here, say "I'd have to find out."
Give one vague answer each round on purpose, and see if they follow it up.

Brackwell Engineering

A made-up apprenticeship provider

WHAT IT IS	A two-year engineering apprenticeship.
THE WEEK	Four days at work and one day at college. 7.30 to 4.00 on work days.
ASSESSED	Coursework and practical tests at college, and a final assessment at the end.
PAY	Paid from the first day, at least the apprentice minimum wage.
SUPPORT	A mentor at work, and a college tutor who visits every twelve weeks.
COSTS	None for the training. Boots and overalls are provided.
LAST YEAR	Nine in ten apprentices were offered a job at the end.
IF IT GOES WRONG	Talk to the training manager. You can move onto a college course.

Answer from this card. If it isn't here, say "I'd have to find out."
Give one vague answer each round on purpose, and see if they follow it up.





Build your questions

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NAME

FORM

RANK

MONDAY The course, the teaching and the people.

☐

How is it assessed, and how much of that is exams?

☐

Who teaches first years: lecturers, or postgraduate students?

☐

What would I actually be doing in week three of the first term?

☐

Who do I go to if I am struggling, with the work or with anything else?

☐

What do students do here who are not into the nightlife?

☐

One of my own: _____

TUESDAY Money, living, and if it goes wrong.

☐

What does accommodation cost, and is a first-year place guaranteed?

☐

What bursaries or scholarships are there, and how do I apply?

☐

Do students work part-time alongside the course, and does it fit?

☐

Can I change course, and until when?

☐

What happens if I miss the grades in my offer?

☐

One of my own: _____

WEDNESDAY Ask it for real

My best follow-up question, for when an answer is vague:

THURSDAY Set up the open day

☐

I'm a visitor

☐

I'm staff at _____





My questions for the open day

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WHEN

1



WHAT I FOUND OUT

☐

2



WHAT I FOUND OUT

☐

3



WHAT I FOUND OUT

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WHAT I FOUND OUT

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5



WHAT I FOUND OUT

☐

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Who, exactly?

How much?

By when?

Can you give me an example?

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THEY SAY

"We have a really strong support network."

TRY ASKING

"Who do I go to, and how quickly can I see them?"

THEY SAY

"Our graduates go on to great things."

TRY ASKING

"What did last year's graduates actually do?"

THEY SAY

"There's a good mix of teaching."

TRY ASKING

"How many hours of small-group teaching a week?"

THEY SAY

"Most first years get a place in halls."

TRY ASKING

"Is a place guaranteed, and what if I apply late?"

THEY SAY

"There's lots of financial support."

TRY ASKING

"Which bursaries, how much, and who can get one?"

THEY SAY

"We're quite flexible about changing course."

TRY ASKING

"Until when, and what would I have to do?"

THEY SAY

"There's something for everyone here."

TRY ASKING

"What do students who aren't into the nightlife do?"

THEY SAY

"We look at every application individually."

TRY ASKING

"What happens if I miss my offer by a grade?"





Stall cards

Cut out, one copy. Two students run each stall and answer only from their card. The places are made up, and the gaps on the cards are deliberate.

University of Aldermoor

A made-up university · History

ASSESSED	About 60 per cent essays and projects, 40 per cent exams.
CONTACT HOURS	9 a week in the first year: 5 lectures and 4 seminars of about 14.
WHO TEACHES	Lecturers give the lectures. Some first-year seminars are run by PhD students.
WEEK THREE	The first essay is set, due in week six. Expect about 8 hours of reading a week.
SUPPORT	A personal tutor for all three years, and a wellbeing service with same-week appointments.
ACCOMMODATION	Guaranteed in the first year if Aldermoor is your firm choice. £150 to £220 a week.
MONEY	A £1,000 bursary each year if your household income is under £30,000.
MISSED GRADES	Looked at on results day. One grade below the offer is often still accepted.

Answer from this card. If it isn't here, say "I'd have to find out."
Give one vague answer each round on purpose, and see if they follow it up.

Kellingford University

A made-up university · Computer Science

ASSESSED	Half exams, half coursework and group projects.
CONTACT HOURS	14 a week: 6 of lectures, 6 in labs and 2 in tutorials of eight.
WHO TEACHES	Lecturers give the lectures. Postgraduate students help in the labs.
WEEK THREE	Your first programming assignment is due.
PEOPLE	250 on the course. The biggest society is the board games society.
ACCOMMODATION	Not guaranteed, but about 9 in 10 first years get a place. From £130 a week.
PART-TIME WORK	A jobs service on campus. The advice is no more than 15 hours a week.
CHANGING	In the first two weeks, into Maths or Data Science.

Answer from this card. If it isn't here, say "I'd have to find out."
Give one vague answer each round on purpose, and see if they follow it up.

Saltmere University

A made-up university · Nursing

ASSESSED	Half on placement, half at university: essays, exams and practical tests.
CONTACT HOURS	Far more than most courses. Placements are full shifts, including some nights and weekends.
WHO TEACHES	Lecturers who are registered nurses, and a mentor on each placement.
WEEK THREE	In the classroom and the skills lab. The first placement starts in the second term.
SUPPORT	A personal tutor, and a phone line for problems on placement.
MONEY	Eligible students in England can get an NHS grant of at least £5,000 a year.
ACCOMMODATION	First years who apply by the deadline get a place. £140 to £190 a week.
CHANGING	You can switch to another health course in the first term, if there are places.

Answer from this card. If it isn't here, say "I'd have to find out."
Give one vague answer each round on purpose, and see if they follow it up.

Pennant Systems

A made-up company · Degree apprenticeship

WHAT IT IS	A four-year software engineering degree apprenticeship. You finish with a degree.
THE WEEK	Four days at work and one day of university study.
ASSESSED	University coursework and exams, and a final assessment at work.
MONEY	A salary from the first day. You pay no tuition fees.
WHO TEACHES	University lecturers, and a mentor at work.
PEOPLE	Twelve apprentices start each year.
LIVING	No accommodation is provided. Most apprentices live at home.
IF IT GOES WRONG	You can leave and apply to university in the usual way.

Answer from this card. If it isn't here, say "I'd have to find out."
Give one vague answer each round on purpose, and see if they follow it up.

